Japanese Writing System

There are three kinds of characters in Japanese: *hiragana*, *katakana*, and kanji.[1] All three characters can be seen in a single sentence.

テ レ ビ を 見 ま す。　　*I watch television.*
katakana　　kanji *hiragana*

Hiragana and *katakana*, like the alphabet, represent sounds. As you can see in the above example, *hiragana* has a roundish shape and is used for conjugation endings, function words, and native Japanese words not covered by kanji. *Katakana*, which has rather straight lines, is normally used for writing loanwords and foreign names. For example, the Japanese word for "television" is written in *katakana* as テレビ (*terebi*). Kanji, or Chinese characters, represent not just sounds but also meanings. Mostly, kanji are used for nouns and the stems of verbs and adjectives.

I Hiragana

1. Basic *Hiragana* Syllables

There are forty-six basic *hiragana* syllables, which are listed below. Once you memorize this chart, you will have the skill to transcribe all of the Japanese sounds. (The romanization is given for general pronunciation reference.)

JWS-01

あ *a*	い *i*	う *u*	え *e*	お *o*
か *ka*	き *ki*	く *ku*	け *ke*	こ *ko*
さ *sa*	し **shi*	す *su*	せ *se*	そ *so*
た *ta*	ち **chi*	つ **tsu*	て *te*	と *to*
な *na*	に *ni*	ぬ *nu*	ね *ne*	の *no*
は *ha*	ひ *hi*	ふ **fu*	へ *he*	ほ *ho*

* The syllables し, ち, つ, and ふ are romanized as *shi*, *chi*, *tsu*, and *fu*, respectively, to closely resemble English pronunciation.

[1] There is another writing system called *rōmaji* (Roman letters), which is used for station names, signs, and so on.

ま *ma*	み *mi*	む *mu*	め *me*	も *mo*
や *ya*		ゆ *yu*		よ *yo*
ら *ra*	り *ri*	る *ru*	れ *re*	ろ *ro*
わ *wa*				**を *o*
ん *n*				

** を is also pronounced as "*wo*."

2. *Hiragana* with Diacritical Marks

You can transcribe 23 additional sounds by adding diacritic marks. With a pair of short diagonal strokes (゛), the unvoiced consonants *k, s, t,* and *h* become voiced consonants *g, z, d,* and *b,* respectively. The consonant *h* changes to *p* with the addition of a small circle (゜).

JWS-02

が *ga*	ぎ *gi*	ぐ *gu*	げ *ge*	ご *go*
ざ *za*	じ *ji*	ず *zu*	ぜ *ze*	ぞ *zo*
だ *da*	*ぢ *ji*	*づ *zu*	で *de*	ど *do*
ば *ba*	び *bi*	ぶ *bu*	べ *be*	ぼ *bo*
ぱ *pa*	ぴ *pi*	ぷ *pu*	ぺ *pe*	ぽ *po*

* ぢ (*ji*) and づ (*zu*) are pronounced the same as じ (*ji*) and ず (*zu*), respectively, and have limited use.

3. Transcribing Contracted Sounds

Small や, ゆ, and よ follow after letters in the second column (*i*-vowel *hiragana*, except い) and are used to transcribe contracted sounds. The contracted sound represents a single syllable.

きゃ kya	きゅ kyu	きょ kyo
しゃ sha	しゅ shu	しょ sho
ちゃ cha	ちゅ chu	ちょ cho
にゃ nya	にゅ nyu	にょ nyo
ひゃ hya	ひゅ hyu	ひょ hyo
みゃ mya	みゅ myu	みょ myo
りゃ rya	りゅ ryu	りょ ryo

ぎゃ gya	ぎゅ gyu	ぎょ gyo
じゃ ja	じゅ ju	じょ jo

JWS-03

びゃ bya	びゅ byu	びょ byo
ぴゃ pya	ぴゅ pyu	ぴょ pyo

4. Transcribing Double Consonants

There is another small letter, っ, which is used when transcribing double consonants such as *tt* and *pp*.

Example JWS-04

かった	*katta*	(won)	cf. かた	*kata*	(shoulder)
さっか	*sakka*	(writer)			
はっぱ	*happa*	(leaf)			
ざっし	*zasshi*	(magazine)			

Note double consonant *n*'s as in *sannen* (three years) are written with ん + a *hiragana* with an initial *n* sound (な, に, ぬ, ね, and の).

Example JWS-05

さんねん	*sannen*	(three years)
あんない	*annai*	(guide)

5. Other Issues Relating to Transcription and Pronunciation

A. Long Vowels

When the same vowel is placed one right after the other, the pronunciation of the vowel becomes about twice as long as the single vowel. Be sure to hold the sound long enough, because the length of the vowel can change one word to another.

JWS-06

aa	おばあさん	*obaasan*	(grandmother)	cf. おばさん	*obasan*	(aunt)
ii	おじいさん	*ojiisan*	(grandfather)	cf. おじさん	*ojisan*	(uncle)
uu	すうじ	*suuji*	(number)			

ee The long *ee* sound is usually transcribed by adding an い to an *e*-vowel *hiragana*. There are a few words, however, in which え is used instead of い.

えいが	*eega*	(movie)
おねえさん	*oneesan*	(big sister)

oo The long *oo* sound is in most cases transcribed by adding an う to an *o*-vowel *hiragana*. There are, however, words in which the long vowel is transcribed with an お, for historical reasons.

ほうりつ	*hooritsu*	(law)
とお	*too*	(ten)

B. Pronunciation of ん

ん (*n*) is treated like a full syllable, in terms of length. Its pronunciation varies, however, depending on the sound that follows it. Japanese speakers are normally not aware of the different sound values of ん. Therefore, you do not need to worry too much about its pronunciation.[2]

C. Vowels to Be Dropped

The vowels *i* and *u* are sometimes dropped when placed between voiceless consonants (*k, s, t, p,* and *h*), or at the end of an utterance preceded by voiceless consonants.

Example JWS-07

すきです *s(u)kides(u)* (I like it.)

D. Accent in the Japanese Language

Japanese has pitch accent: all syllables are pronounced basically either in high or low pitch. Unlike English stress accent in which stressed syllables tend to be pronounced longer and louder, in Japanese each syllable is pronounced approximately in equal length and stress. The pitch patterns in Japanese vary greatly, depending on the region of the country.

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[2] One variety of the ん pronunciation merits discussing here. When it is followed by a vowel or at the end of an utterance, ん indicates that the preceding vowel is long and nasalized. (Nasalized vowels are shown here with a tilde above vowel letters. You hear nasalized vowels in French words such as "bon," or the English interjection "uh-uh," as in "no.")

e.g. れんあい *rẽai* (romance) ほん *hõ* (book)

Followed by *n, t, d, s,* and *z* sounds, ん is pronounced as "n."	**e.g.** おんな	*onna*	(woman)
Followed by *m, p,* and *b* sounds, ん is pronounced as "m."	**e.g.** さんぽ	*sampo*	(stroll)
Followed by *k* and *g* sounds, ん is pronounced as "ng" as in "song."	**e.g.** まんが	*maŋga*	(comics)

Example JWS-08

あさ　a sa　(morning)

なまえ　na ma e　(name)

たかい　ta ka i　(high)

II Katakana

1. Basic *Katakana* Syllables

JWS-09

ア *a*	イ *i*	ウ *u*	エ *e*	オ *o*
カ *ka*	キ *ki*	ク *ku*	ケ *ke*	コ *ko*
サ *sa*	シ **shi*	ス *su*	セ *se*	ソ *so*
タ *ta*	チ **chi*	ツ **tsu*	テ *te*	ト *to*
ナ *na*	ニ *ni*	ヌ *nu*	ネ *ne*	ノ *no*
ハ *ha*	ヒ *hi*	フ **fu*	ヘ *he*	ホ *ho*
マ *ma*	ミ *mi*	ム *mu*	メ *me*	モ *mo*
ヤ *ya*		ユ *yu*		ヨ *yo*
ラ *ra*	リ *ri*	ル *ru*	レ *re*	ロ *ro*
ワ *wa*				ヲ *o*
ン *n*				

*The syllables シ, チ, ツ, and フ are romanized as *shi*, *chi*, *tsu*, and *fu*, respectively, to closely resemble English pronunciation.

2. *Katakana* with Diacritical Marks

JWS-10

ガ *ga*	ギ *gi*	グ *gu*	ゲ *ge*	ゴ *go*
ザ *za*	ジ *ji*	ズ *zu*	ゼ *ze*	ゾ *zo*
ダ *da*	*ヂ *ji*	*ヅ *zu*	デ *de*	ド *do*
バ *ba*	ビ *bi*	ブ *bu*	ベ *be*	ボ *bo*
パ *pa*	ピ *pi*	プ *pu*	ペ *pe*	ポ *po*

*ヂ (*ji*) and ヅ (*zu*) are pronounced the same as ジ (*ji*) and ズ (*zu*), respectively, and have limited use.

3. Transcribing Contracted Sounds

キャ *kya*	キュ *kyu*	キョ *kyo*
シャ *sha*	シュ *shu*	ショ *sho*
チャ *cha*	チュ *chu*	チョ *cho*
ニャ *nya*	ニュ *nyu*	ニョ *nyo*
ヒャ *hya*	ヒュ *hyu*	ヒョ *hyo*
ミャ *mya*	ミュ *myu*	ミョ *myo*
リャ *rya*	リュ *ryu*	リョ *ryo*

JWS-11

ギャ *gya*	ギュ *gyu*	ギョ *gyo*
ジャ *ja*	ジュ *ju*	ジョ *jo*

ビャ *bya*	ビュ *byu*	ビョ *byo*
ピャ *pya*	ピュ *pyu*	ピョ *pyo*

4. Other Issues Relating to Transcription and Pronunciation

The pronunciation of *katakana* and its combinations are the same as those of *hiragana*, except for the following points.

A. Long Vowels

The long vowels are written with ー.

Example JWS-12

カー	*kaa*	(car)	ケーキ	*keeki*	(cake)
スキー	*sukii*	(ski)	ボール	*booru*	(ball)
スーツ	*suutsu*	(suit)			

When you write vertically, the ー mark needs to be written vertically also.

ボール → ボ
ー
ル

B. Transcribing Foreign Sounds

Additional combinations with small vowel letters are used to transcribe foreign sounds which originally did not exist in Japanese.

Example JWS-13

ウィ	ハロウィーン	*harowiin*	(Halloween)
ウェ	ハイウェイ	*haiwee*	(highway)
ウォ	ミネラルウォーター	*mineraruwootaa*	(mineral water)
シェ	シェフ	*shefu*	(chef)
ジェ	ジェームス	*Jeemusu*	(James)
チェ	チェック	*chekku*	(check)
ファ	ファッション	*fasshon*	(fashion)
フィ	フィリピン	*Firipin*	(Philippines)
フェ	カフェ	*kafe*	(cafe)
フォ	フォーク	*fooku*	(fork)
ティ	パーティー	*paatii*	(party)
ディ	ディズニーランド	*Dizuniirando*	(Disneyland)
デュ	デュエット	*dyuetto*	(duet)

The sound "v" is sometimes written with ヴ. For example, the word "Venus" is sometimes written as ビーナス or ヴィーナス.

Ⅲ Kanji

Kanji are Chinese characters which were introduced to Japan more than 1,500 years ago when the Japanese language did not have a writing system. *Hiragana* and *katakana* evolved later in Japan based on the simplified Chinese characters.

Kanji represent both meanings and sounds. Most kanji possess multiple readings, which are divided into two types: *on-yomi* (Chinese readings) and *kun-yomi* (Japanese readings). *On-yomi* are derived from the pronunciations used in China. Some kanji have more than one *on-yomi* due to temporal and regional variances in the Chinese pronunciation. *Kun-yomi* are Japanese readings.

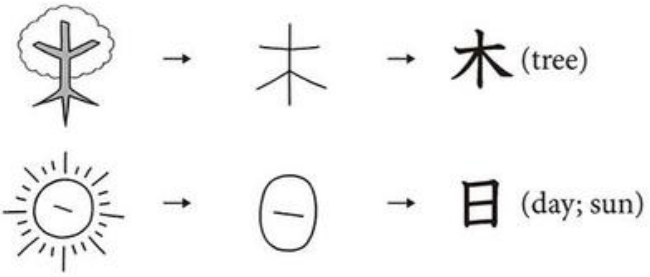
When people started to use kanji to write native Japanese words, Japanese readings (*kun-yomi*) were added to kanji.

By the time of high school graduation, Japanese are expected to know 2,136 kanji (called Joyo Kanji), which are designated by the Ministry of Education as commonly used kanji. A total of 1,006 kanji are taught at the elementary school level, and most of the remainder are taught in junior high school.

There are roughly four types of kanji, based on their formation.

A. Pictograms

Some kanji are made from pictures:



B. Simple ideograms

Some kanji are made of dots and lines to represent numbers or abstract concepts.



C. Compound ideograms

Some kanji are made from the combination of two or more kanji.

日 (day; sun) + 月 (moon) → 明 (bright)

人 (person) + 木 (tree) → 休 (to rest)

D. Phonetic-ideographic characters

Some kanji are made up of a meaning element and a sound element.

Meaning element		Sound element		*On-yomi*
氵 (water)	+	青 *sei* (blue)	→	清 *sei* (clean)
日 (day; sun)	+	青 *sei* (blue)	→	晴 *sei* (clear sky)